HALIFAX STORY HUNT

Organizer guide

An hour-long, free, on-foot team activity for 38 colleagues in downtown Halifax. Each team follows its own route of three historic doors (plus an optional fourth), reads a short story aloud at each one, then earns points at the real place.

GROUP	38 people in 6 teams: four teams of 6 and two teams of 7. Each team number has its own route, so teams spread out and are not scheduled at the same door at the same time.
ROUTE	Six doors, all outdoors, all free, all within about 12 minutes' walk of the Cambridge Suites (1583 Brunswick St). Teams do about four.
PER DOOR	Open the stop's story, read it aloud (about 70 seconds), answer one listening question, complete one look-around challenge, take a guide photo and a creative photo, and have the scribe submit them in the form.
EACH PHONE	A camera and mobile data. If data fails, Appendix A has the same stories and challenges on paper.
COST	$0. You print the packets. Nothing needs a ticket. Province House and St. Paul's have optional free interiors.

Run of show

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS
2:30	Teams gather in the lobby. Hand out packets and pens. Teams are assigned beforehand, or draw numbers 1 to 6 from a hat.
2:35	Three-minute briefing (script on page 4). Launch all six teams.
2:35–3:20	Teams out on the route. Control stays at the hotel with the phone, the answer key and the backup cards.
3:20	Hard return. Late teams lose 3 points per minute. Judges review the form submissions (and any backup scorecards).
3:20–3:30	Photo vote: teams show their favourite creative photo while judges total the scores. Teams vote. Awards at 3:30.

Who you need

- **Control** (1 person, stays at the hotel): holds the scoreboard, takes calls from teams, keeps the weather call.
- **Judge** (1 or 2 people, can include Control): checks submissions in the form's spreadsheet at 3:20 using the answer key.
- **Roamer** (optional): stands at the Grand Parade between 2:40 and 3:10 to help with the St. Paul's and Cenotaph doors.

Before the day

BY	DO THIS
Nov 10	Open the story page on three phones (iPhone, Android, one on mobile data only), then scan the packet QR code, pick a team and click through every stop. Have each scribe open the submission form once (work sign-in and MFA on mobile data). The page is shared by link, so set its sharing so anyone with the link can open it, and confirm it opens when you are signed out.
Nov 17	Walk the route on a weekday afternoon, ideally 2:30–3:30. Do each "site check" in the answer key and time yourself. Adjust the walking times if you are slower or faster.
Nov 20	Phone St. Paul's (902-429-2241): say a large group will pass through for a few minutes before 3:00 on Nov 24, and confirm hours. Look at Parks Canada's Citadel page for Nov 23–24 events.
Nov 23	Check the forecast. Make the weather call (page 9) by 1:45 pm on Nov 24 at the latest.
Nov 24, 2:00	Control table set up with packets, pens, scoreboard, the Appendix A cards in an envelope, and the packet QR code (page 2) for last-minute tests.

Control scoreboard

Fill in at 3:20 as judges report. Total = door points + D6 bonus - late penalty + photo vote.

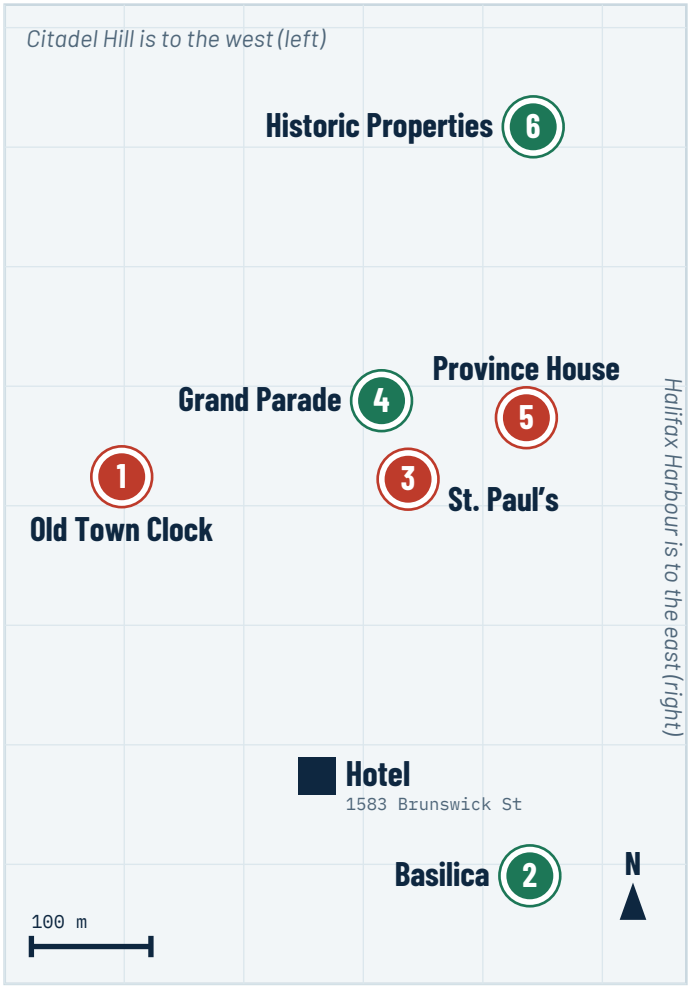
TEAM	D1	D2	D3	D4	D5	D6	D6+5	LATE	VOTE	TOTAL
Team 1										
Team 2										
Team 3										
Team 4										
Team 5										
Team 6										

Test the QR code (Control, 2:00 pm)

This is the same code printed on page 1 of every team packet. It opens the Halifax Story Hunt page. Scan it on a phone with mobile data and pick a team.

The six doors

Positions are to scale. Streets are left off on purpose: use phone maps for turn-by-turn. Walking times assume a group at about 4.5 km/h with a small allowance for hills.



Walking minutes

Read across: from the row to the column. Uphill legs are the slower numbers (the way back to the hotel).

MIN	H	1	2	3	4	5	6
Hotel		6	4	5	6	6	10
1. Clock	5		9	4	4	6	8
2. Basilica	4	10		8	9	7	11
3. St. Paul's	6	5	6		1	2	6
4. Grand Parade	7	5	8	1		2	5
5. Province House	8	7	7	2	3		4
6. Historic Properties	12	10	11	7	6	4	

What to expect

- Doors 3 and 4 are neighbours, about a minute apart.
- Door 2 is the only door south of the hotel. Door 6 is the farthest, and the climb back is the steepest.
- Hotel to Province House and the Grand Parade is downhill. Everything back is uphill.

Team routes

Each team's first three stops are the core hunt, planned at about 6 minutes a door. The fourth is optional. Routes were chosen so that no two teams are scheduled at the same door at the same stop. Real timing will drift, so use the Control phone.

TEAM	STOPS 1 TO 3	OPTIONAL 4TH	CORE WALK	CORE FINISH
Team 1	1, 3, 2	5	20 min	back by about 3:09
Team 2	2, 1, 4	6	25 min	back by about 3:11
Team 3	3, 2, 1	4	26 min	back by about 3:14
Team 4	4, 6, 5	3	23 min	back by about 3:08
Team 5	5, 4, 6	1	26 min	back by about 3:07
Team 6	6, 5, 3	2	22 min	back by about 3:09

Briefing and launch

Three minutes at 2:30 in the lobby. Adapt the first paragraph to your workplace's usual practice.

"Thank you for being outside with us in late November. We are about to walk in Kjipuktuk, the Mi'kmaw name for Halifax harbour, which means Great Harbour. This is Mi'kma'ki, the traditional and unceded territory of the Mi'kmaq."

"Downtown Halifax has six doors. Each is a real place within a short walk. Your team has its own route, so you will not meet another team at the same door at the same time. Scan the code on your packet, tap your team number, and the page tells you where to go first."

"At each door, one person reads the story aloud while someone photographs them with the place behind. Then answer the listening question, do the look-around and take the creative photo. Your scribe submits it in the form, with your team number and the door, then tap Done and the page sends you to the next door. Every team does three doors. A fourth is optional if you are ahead of schedule."

"Stay together, use crosswalks, walk, and watch for ice. St. Paul's closes about 3:00, so go early if you want the inside. Be back in this lobby by 3:20. Every minute late costs three points. Your safety lead sets the pace. If anyone is cold or tired, call Control and head back."

"At 3:20 each team shows us its favourite creative photo, and we vote. Questions? Go."

Team formation

- Teams 1 to 4: six people. Teams 5 and 6: seven people. Mix departments. Teams can name themselves in the lobby.
- Pre-assign if you can. If drawing from a hat, draw numbers 1 to 6. The team number sets the route.
- Give each team a packet (3 pages) and one pen. Write the Control phone number on the cover strip of each packet.

Questions you will hear

QUESTION	ANSWER
Can we split up to cover more doors?	No. The team stays together, and everyone should hear every story.
A place is closed. What now?	Do the outside version. Each door lists one in the answer key. Points are the same.
Does the answer have to be word for word?	No. Judges should be generous. The aim is a fun hour, not an exam.
Can we skip a door?	Yes. Nobody needs all six.
Phone has no data or the page will not load?	Use a teammate's phone. If nobody has data, call Control and see page 9.

Scoring and judging

AT EACH DOOR	WHAT EARNS IT	PTS
Guide photo	Photo of the teammate reading the story aloud, landmark behind them.	5
Listen question	Answer from the story.	10
Look-around	Find it, count it or photograph it at the real place.	10
Creative photo	The photo challenge for that door.	5
Door total	Most any team can earn per door	30

Bonuses and penalties

ITEM	RULE	PTS
Door 6	Historic Properties is the farthest door.	+5
Late return	Every minute after 3:20.	-3 per min
Votes	Each team casts one vote for Best Creative Photo. Teams cannot vote for themselves. The winner gets +10.	+10

How judges work at 3:20

- Open the form's spreadsheet. For each submission check the guide photo and creative photo, then the answers against the key. Judges check the photo shows the right place and the right pose.
- Award partial points freely. If a photo is unclear, ask for a quick re-description rather than zero.
- Typical scores: four doors at full marks is 120. With the Door 6 bonus and the photo vote a strong team reaches about 135.
- Tie-break: more doors visited, then the photo vote.

Awards (free)

- **Top Navigators**: highest total.
- **Best Creative Photo**: team vote.
- **Staying Power**: earliest back with at least three doors.

Answer key and site checks

Do each site check on your walk-through. Points are in brackets. Accept reasonable wording.

1 Old Town Clock

TIME AND THE CROWN

LISTEN	**Who ordered the clock, and what problem was it meant to solve?** (10) Prince Edward, Duke of Kent (5). To fix the garrison's lateness / keep the troops punctual (5).
LOOK	**Look at the clock faces. What colour are they? Write it down.** (10) Blue (the faces are painted cobalt blue). Give 10 for blue.
PHOTO	Late for parade! Freeze in a mid-stride pose, everyone looking at the clock. Mime it: no running on the street. (5). Guide photo (5): the reader mid-story with the landmark visible.
HOURS	Outdoors, always accessible. Stay at street level: the grass slope is steep and may be icy.
SITE CHECK	Confirm on the walk-through that the faces read as blue from the sidewalk and that the spot at the base of the hill is not iced over.

2 St. Mary's Basilica

GRANITE AND FAITH

LISTEN	**Who was hired to build the roof, and why was that a good fit?** (10) Shipwrights (5). No local craftsman had roofed anything this big; shipwrights framed it like a ship's hull (5).
LOOK	**Count the main doorways (portals) across the granite front. Write the number.** (10) 3. (Canada's Historic Places describes three portals with pink Aberdeen granite shafts; confirm on the walk-through.)
PHOTO	Human spire: tallest teammate in the centre, everyone else stepping down on each side to make a spire shape. No climbing. (5). Guide photo (5): the reader mid-story with the landmark visible.
HOURS	Exterior only is fine. The church is generally open Mon–Fri 8:30–12 and 1–4:30 if a team wants to peek in (quiet voices).
SITE CHECK	Confirm the count of three main doorways from the sidewalk across Spring Garden Rd.

3 St. Paul's Church

THE OLDEST WALLS

LISTEN	**In what year was St. Paul's founded, and what do the two Explosion reminders in the church look like?** (10) 1749 (5; accept 1750 for the cornerstone). A window frame in the entrance wall and a window with a face profile in the glass (5 for either).
LOOK	**INSIDE (if open before 2:55): find the piece of window frame lodged in the entrance wall. What does the plaque beside it say? OUTSIDE (if closed): photograph the whole team with the full church behind you.** (10) Inside: "A Relic of the Explosion" for 10. Outside alternative: photo with the whole church visible for 10.
PHOTO	Portrait from 1750: line up like a formal portrait and keep a perfectly serious face. (5). Guide photo (5): the reader mid-story with the landmark visible.
HOURS	Interior relics are visible only when the church is open. Posted hours for Tuesdays run about 9:00–3:00, so go early (before 2:55). Self-guided visits are free; quiet voices, no food or drink.
SITE CHECK	Call St. Paul's office (902-429-2241) ahead to say a large group will pass through for a few minutes before 3:00 on Nov 24, and confirm where the window frame relic is (entrance wall) and that the plaque is readable.

4 Grand Parade

THE TOWN SQUARE

LISTEN	**Who unveiled the Cenotaph, and what does the bronze figure on top represent?** (10) Former Prime Minister Robert Borden (5). Britannia, representing Nova Scotia's mothers (5).
LOOK	**Walk around the Cenotaph and list every conflict named on it.** (10) Expect World War I, World War II, Korea and Afghanistan. 3 or more correct = 10; 2 = 5. Walk the Cenotaph on your site visit to confirm the wording.
PHOTO	Town crier: record a 10-second announcement of your team's biggest news. Do it at the City Hall end, not near the Cenotaph. (5). Guide photo (5): the reader mid-story with the landmark visible.
HOURS	Open air, always accessible. The Cenotaph is a memorial: no clowning near it.
SITE CHECK	Walk all four sides of the Cenotaph and note the exact conflicts listed.

5 Province House

FREE PRESS

LISTEN	**What was Joseph Howe charged with, and about how long did the jury take to decide?** (10) Seditious (criminal) libel (5). About ten minutes (5).
LOOK	**On the grounds, photograph the Joseph Howe statue (5 points) and find one other monument and write its name (5 points).** (10) Howe statue photo = 5. Other monument: the South African War memorial = 5 (accept any other monument they photograph and name correctly).
PHOTO	Front page: write a one-line headline about your team's afternoon on paper and hold it up in front of the building. (5). Guide photo (5): the reader mid-story with the landmark visible.
HOURS	Inside is free but needs photo ID and security screening (open Mon–Fri 8:30–4:00, last entry 3:30). Plan on the grounds only. If the garden gate is closed, work from the sidewalk and fence.
SITE CHECK	Confirm whether the Prince St garden gate is open in the afternoon. If not, check what you can see of the Howe statue from the fence.

6 Historic Properties

SEA AND TRADE

LISTEN	**What is a privateer, and which privateer-turned-banker is linked to the Privateers' Warehouse?** (10) A privately owned ship licensed by a government to capture enemy merchant ships (5). Enos Collins (5).
LOOK	**Find the Privateers' Warehouse: a stone building with small windows and loading doors on the ground floor. Photograph it and write how many storeys it has.** (10) About three and a half storeys. Accept 3, 3½ or 4 for 10 points if the photo shows the right building (sources differ; confirm on site).
PHOTO	Licensed crew: pose as a ship's crew with a captain pointing at the horizon and everyone in a role. (5). Guide photo (5): the reader mid-story with the landmark visible.
HOURS	The farthest door and the steepest walk back. The boardwalk is outdoors. Shops are generally open 10–6 on weekdays. Door 6 earns a +5 distance bonus.
SITE CHECK	Locate the Privateers' Warehouse on site and confirm which building has signage or a plaque. Count storeys from the boardwalk side.

If things go sideways

Weather

CONDITIONS	CALL
Dry or light rain, sidewalks clear	Run as planned. Remind people about boots and layers by email the day before.
Steady rain or snow, windy, but sidewalks safe	Run, and tell teams Doors 5 and 6 are optional. Drop the Door 6 bonus if you want to keep them close.
Freezing rain, icy sidewalks, or a wind warning	Switch to Plan B by 1:45 pm.

Plan B (indoor, same hour). Same teams, meeting room. Control reads three door stories from Appendix A. Teams answer the Listen questions (30 points), build the three creative photos in the hotel (15 points) and vote on the best photo. Same awards, 3:30 finish.

Closures and fallbacks

PROBLEM	FALLBACK
St. Paul's is closed or locked	Use the outside photo version of the Look-around (10 points).
Province House gate is closed	Work from the fence. Accept the Howe statue or any monument seen through it; if none is visible, give the 10 points for a photo of the building front.
The hill below the Clock is icy	Teams stay on the sidewalk. The clock face is visible from there.
Grand Parade has a stage or event set up	Fine. Teams walk around it. If the Cenotaph is fenced, accept the listing from the Remembrance panels or skip the Look-around for full marks.
A team's phone has no data	Another team member's phone, or call Control to send a photo of the backup card.
The form will not open or sign-in fails	Try a different teammate's phone (the scribe role can pass). If nobody can sign in, use the backup scorecard on page 3 of the packet and show photos on the phone at 3:20.
The QR page will not open	Type the address printed on page 2 of the packet. If it still fails, Control hands out the Appendix A card.

Safety, access and respect

- Teams of 6 or 7 only. The Safety lead sets the pace and walks with the slowest walker.
- Any teammate who prefers not to do hills can join as a team's "Base" at the hotel: they keep time, keep the phone number and photograph the others' return.
- St. Paul's, St. Mary's and the Cenotaph are places of worship and remembrance. Quiet voices, no flash inside, no jokes at the Cenotaph.
- Province House is a working legislature with security screening and photo ID. We only visit the grounds. No climbing on statues.

Open items to confirm

- Whether the Citadel's "Victorian Christmas" (Nov 23–24, noon to 4 pm on Parks Canada's hours page) applies in 2026; St. Paul's hours on Nov 24 (posted 9:00–3:00 or 10:00–3:00); which relics are visible inside St. Paul's; the Cenotaph conflict list; which building is the Privateers' Warehouse.

Appendix A: Backup story cards

Cut or fold. Use if a phone has no data or the page will not open. Same text as the story page.

1 Old Town Clock

TIME AND THE CROWN

READ ALOUD

You are standing at the foot of Citadel Hill. Halifax has been a garrison town since 1749, and one of its commanders, Prince Edward, Duke of Kent, had a famous obsession: punctuality. The clock was designed in 1801 by his engineer as a parting gift, to keep the garrison on time. Prince Edward had already left Halifax by then. The clock began keeping time on October 20, 1803. Its works were made in London by the House of Vulliamy, a famous family of royal clockmakers, and the original mechanism is still running. Three heavy weights drive it, and Parks Canada winds it twice a week. The tower around it was largely rebuilt in the early 1960s. Prince Edward went on to become the father of Queen Victoria. Before you leave, look up at the clock face and take a good look at its colour.

LISTEN (10)	Who ordered the clock, and what problem was it meant to solve?
LOOK (10)	Look at the clock faces. What colour are they? Write it down.
PHOTO (5)	Late for parade! Freeze in a mid-stride pose, everyone looking at the clock. Mime it: no running on the street.

2 St. Mary's Basilica

GRANITE AND FAITH

READ ALOUD

This is Saint Mary's Cathedral Basilica. After the penal laws against Catholics were repealed, a Catholic church was built on this site in 1784, the first in Halifax. In 1820 it was replaced by a stone church, built of local ironstone. Nobody in town had built a roof this big, so shipwrights were hired, and they framed it the way they would build the hull of a ship. The granite front and the spire came later, in the 1860s and 1870s, and pink Aberdeen granite shafts frame the three doorways. The cross was set on top of the spire on September 7, 1874. The spire is 189 feet tall and is said to be the highest free-standing granite spire in North America. On December 6, 1917, the Halifax Explosion shattered the stained glass windows, and some of the bells cracked and were sent to England to be recast. Each year a Treaty Day Mass here remembers the 1752 agreement between the Mi'kmaq and the British.

LISTEN (10)	Who was hired to build the roof, and why was that a good fit?
LOOK (10)	Count the main doorways (portals) across the granite front. Write the number.
PHOTO (5)	Human spire: tallest teammate in the centre, everyone else stepping down on each side to make a spire shape. No climbing.

3 St. Paul's Church

THE OLDEST WALLS

READ ALOUD

St. Paul's was founded in 1749, the same year as Halifax itself, and its cornerstone was laid the following summer. It is the oldest building in Halifax and is called the oldest Protestant church in Canada. Its frame was cut in New England and shipped north. In 1917 the Halifax Explosion blew out the windows but left the church standing, and the building kept two reminders. One is a piece of window frame lodged in the wall of the entrance, with a plaque beside it that reads "A Relic of the Explosion." The other is a gallery window where the glass broke in the shape of a human profile. Stories differ about whose face it is: one tells of a clergyman standing at that window, and other tellers have darker versions. Nobody can say for sure. The explosion killed nearly 2,000 people and injured about 9,000, and this church is one of the places where Halifax keeps that memory in plain sight.

LISTEN (10)	In what year was St. Paul's founded, and what do the two Explosion reminders in the church look like?
LOOK (10)	INSIDE (if open before 2:55): find the piece of window frame lodged in the entrance wall. What does the plaque beside it say? OUTSIDE (if closed): photograph the whole team with the full church behind you.
PHOTO (5)	Portrait from 1750: line up like a formal portrait and keep a perfectly serious face.

4 Grand Parade

THE TOWN SQUARE

READ ALOUD

The Grand Parade has been a focal point of civilian and military life since Halifax was founded in 1749. It began as a parade ground where troops mustered, and the city grew up around it. Today it still works as the town square: Remembrance Day ceremonies, New Year's Eve and the holiday tree lighting all happen here. At the north end stands City Hall, built in 1890. At the south end stands St. Paul's, founded the same year as the city. In the middle is the Cenotaph, about nine metres tall, unveiled on July 1, 1929 by former Prime Minister Robert Borden. The bronze figure on top is Britannia, victorious but grieving, representing Nova Scotia's mothers. Later conflicts were added to the inscriptions over the years, most recently Afghanistan in 2015. This is a place of remembrance, so keep your voices low near the Cenotaph.

LISTEN (10)	Who unveiled the Cenotaph, and what does the bronze figure on top represent?
LOOK (10)	Walk around the Cenotaph and list every conflict named on it.
PHOTO (5)	Town crier: record a 10-second announcement of your team's biggest news. Do it at the City Hall end, not near the Cenotaph.

5 Province House

FREE PRESS

READ ALOUD

Province House is the oldest legislative building in Canada. It was built between 1811 and 1819 of sandstone from Remsheg, now called Wallace, Nova Scotia. The Assembly still meets here. In 1835 the room that is now the Legislative Library was a courtroom, and a newspaper editor named Joseph Howe stood trial there. His paper had printed a letter accusing local officials and police of pocketing a fortune over many years, and he was charged with seditious libel. Howe had no lawyer. He defended himself in a speech that lasted about six hours, by most accounts. The judge pointed the jury toward conviction. The jury took about ten minutes to acquit. The case is remembered as a landmark for freedom of the press in Canada. Howe is honoured by a statue on the grounds.

LISTEN (10)	What was Joseph Howe charged with, and about how long did the jury take to decide?
LOOK (10)	On the grounds, photograph the Joseph Howe statue (5 points) and find one other monument and write its name (5 points).
PHOTO (5)	Front page: write a one-line headline about your team's afternoon on paper and hold it up in front of the building.

6 Historic Properties

SEA AND TRADE

READ ALOUD

Welcome to the waterfront. The Mi'kmaw name for this harbour is Kjipuktuk, meaning Great Harbour, and it is the reason Halifax exists. These stone and wooden warehouses date from about 1800 to the 1870s and were built for merchants and shipping companies. One of them is the Privateers' Warehouse. Privateers were privately owned ships licensed by a government to capture enemy merchant vessels, and in the War of 1812 Nova Scotian privateers captured many American ships. Enos Collins, a privateer who became a banker, is linked to this stone warehouse, which is probably the oldest building left on the Halifax waterfront. In the 1960s the city planned a waterfront expressway and began buying up the warehouses in its path. The buildings were declared a National Historic Site in 1963, and in 1969 council reversed course and agreed to save them. They were restored between 1973 and 1975 into the shops and pubs you see now.

LISTEN (10)	What is a privateer, and which privateer-turned-banker is linked to the Privateers' Warehouse?
LOOK (10)	Find the Privateers' Warehouse: a stone building with small windows and loading doors on the ground floor. Photograph it and write how many storeys it has.
PHOTO (5)	Licensed crew: pose as a ship's crew with a captain pointing at the horizon and everyone in a role.

Sources

Stories and hours were written from these sources (history re-checked November 12, 2026). Where sources disagree, the stories use the more cautious wording.

TOPIC	PAGES
Old Town Clock	parks.canada.ca, Halifax Citadel architecture and buildings page historicplaces.ca, Garrison/Town Clock (id 4260)
St. Mary's Basilica	stmcathedral.com, About the Cathedral en.wikipedia.org/wiki/St._Mary%27s_Basilica_(Halifax,_Nova_Scotia)
St. Paul's Church	historicplaces.ca, St. Paul's Church (id 3065) atlasobscura.com, Face in the Window, St. Paul's Church
Grand Parade and Cenotaph	veterans.gc.ca, Grand Parade Cenotaph hmhps.ca, Grand Parade, City Hall, St. Paul's, Cenotaph globalnews.ca, Cenotaph to include Afghanistan (Oct 15, 2015)
Province House	historicplaces.ca, Province House (id 14222) historicns.library.dal.ca, Province House building (item 142) en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Joseph_Howe
Historic Properties	historicplaces.ca, Historic Properties (id 1536) historicns.library.dal.ca, saving Historic Properties (item 30) en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Enos_Collins
Halifax Explosion and Kjipuktuk	en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Halifax_Explosion en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Halifax,_Nova_Scotia
Hours and access	Parks Canada Citadel pages; nslegislature.ca visitor information; call St. Paul's and the Basilica to confirm

Locations and walking-time estimates use Google Places coordinates. Treat every time as a guess until you have walked it.